

Chapter 91-1

The next day was sunny. Sunlight passed through the thick gray fabric curtains, refracting into the room through the gaps.

Liang Shi's head felt heavy and dull. She instinctively raised her arm to cover her eyes. The weight of her arm gave her eyes a moment of relief, her eyelashes pressed flat. Then, finding it uncomfortable, she turned over and buried her head in the pillow, smelling a strong scent of old wood.

She woke up immediately.

Liang Shi sat on the bed in a daze. The room was empty, the back of her head ached a bit, and her mind was blank.

She reached back to touch the back of her head. There was a small bump.

Hiss...

The pain made her draw in a sharp breath.

Liang Shi couldn't help but complain again—this body's constitution was really no good, unable to handle even that little bit of alcohol.

But she forgot that last night she had been mixing baijiu and Western liquor¹. Seeing how many people in the production were drinking that way, she had tried it too. Plus, she had drunk some before eating, and drank too quickly, so the aftereffects hit hard.

The hangover aftermath showed itself again—when she first woke up, she couldn't remember anything.

But when she reached over to the other side of the bed, it was still warm.

Had she slept with someone?

Or had she just been tossing and turning during the night?

But Liang Shi's behavior when drunk was pretty decent. She shouldn't have done something like fooling around just because she drank too much.

She first got up to open the curtains. The dazzling sunlight made her instinctively squint.

The memories began to slowly return.

Last night, after hanging up the video call with Xu Qingzhu, she had added Gu Yixue on WeChat based on the email, then sent her a "hello" sticker on WeChat.

Gu Yixue had replied with a voice message, her tone lazy and languid, as if she was still smoking, her voice a bit dry: "I drank a bit too much today. Sorry, let's talk about the role tomorrow."

Her Beijing accent² became heavier when she was drunk. Liang Shi had listened to it twice before putting down her phone.

Talk tomorrow?

That meant there really was a role!

She had been happy at the time and a bit thirsty, so she picked up the beer on the hotel table and drank a bottle.

Combined with the alcohol from before kicking in, she became dizzy. She lay on the bed planning to sleep and was almost asleep when she was startled awake by a knock at the door. But she thought she was dreaming.

...

Liang Shi really hated her hangover aftermath.

She wished she could be a second Xu Qingzhu—going crazy after drinking too much, but not remembering any of it afterward.

As long as she wasn't embarrassed, others would be the embarrassed ones.

But Liang Shi would recover all her memories the day after sobering up, with vivid tactile sensations.

The area on her neck seemed to be burning. She went to the bathroom to look, and in the mirror, she saw a strawberry mark³ on the side of her neck.

Sucked out.

Liang Shi: "..."

Not only that, there was also one below her collarbone. Actually, Xu Qingzhu had also bitten her once, but after a night, the teeth marks were gone. The traces from the sucking remained, and after a night of developing, they had become even more vivid.

She immediately checked—there were only marks in these two places on her body.

The most obvious one was on the side of her neck. No matter how Liang Shi tried to cover it, she couldn't hide it, since it was close to her jawline and toward the front.

Liang Shi had accidentally bumped her head on the headboard when she was pulling Xu Qingzhu to lie down on the bed.

It had hurt so much she went numb, and her eyes immediately welled up with tears.

Xu Qingzhu had reached out to rub it for her, and then... she seemed to have buried her head in Xu Qingzhu's chest, taken a particularly indulgent sniff, lightly licked her skin with the tip of her tongue, and said in a low voice: "Teacher Xu, so soft."

Xu Qingzhu had slapped her right on the spot she had just bumped.

The hit made her feel wronged, so Xu Qingzhu rubbed her head again, and then... she fell asleep.

After that... there was no after that.

When Liang Shi woke up and checked the time, it was obvious that Xu Qingzhu had already gotten up and gone to work.

After opening the curtains, she pressed her forehead against the glass and lightly bumped it several times.

Regret, so much regret.

Why did she have to drink?

Drinking too much always led to embarrassment.

Footnotes:

¹ **Baijiu and Western liquor (白酒洋酒):** Baijiu is a strong Chinese distilled spirit typically made from sorghum, with alcohol content usually between 40-60%. Mixing it with Western liquors (like whiskey, vodka, etc.) is generally considered a recipe for getting very drunk very quickly.

² **Beijing accent (京味兒):** A distinctive accent and manner of speaking associated with native Beijing residents, characterized by certain pronunciations and colloquialisms. It often becomes more pronounced when someone is relaxed or intoxicated.

³ **Strawberry mark (草莓印):** Chinese slang for a hickey/love bite, named for its resemblance to a strawberry due to its red color and shape.

Chapter 91-2

The memories from last night made Liang Shi need quite a while to recover. Only after her emotions had mostly calmed down did she take out her phone and switch to the chat interface with Xu Qingzhu. The topmost entry was their video call—ten minutes and fifty seconds.

Not short at all.

She poked at the screen to type: Have you arrived at the company?

—Deleted.

At this hour, she definitely wouldn't have arrived yet. She should still be driving.

She paused and typed again: Have you eaten breakfast?

—Deleted.

When she woke up just now, the sheets beside her were still warm, meaning Xu Qingzhu had only left not long ago. She probably didn't have time to eat either.

She paused again and typed: When did you leave?

—Deleted.

This question sounded very much like something asked after... that. It felt like the next sentence should be—Why aren't you taking responsibility for me?

Having watched too many romance dramas and acted in a few idol dramas herself, Liang Shi felt this wasn't appropriate.

So after struggling for a while, she got up and went to the bathroom to wash up.

She casually tied her hair into a low ponytail, simply washed her face at the small sink, and didn't use the hotel towel. Instead, she pressed tissue paper to her face to absorb the moisture. She didn't really trust the quality of this hotel's toiletries.

Even the pillow had that old wood smell.

Oh right.

Liang Shi thought of something to say as a greeting—she'd ask Xu Qingzhu if she had smelled the old wood scent on the pillow.

Xu Qingzhu had a sensitive nose and was particular about bedding hygiene. Asking her about this now should be the safest option.

But unexpectedly, when Liang Shi picked up her phone, she discovered that she had accidentally sent a period to Xu Qingzhu before locking her phone.

And Xu Qingzhu had already replied: [?]

—[You thought for five minutes and came up with this?]

Liang Shi: "..."

Her feelings were extremely mixed.

Liang Shi poked at the screen: [So you've been watching the chat box the whole time?]

Xu Qingzhu had probably just arrived at the company. She sent a voice message. The background was noisy, with the sounds of cars speeding past and people around her exchanging morning greetings. Xu Qingzhu's voice stood out distinctly among all the noise. She said: "I was going to send a message asking if you were awake, but then I saw the top kept showing 'the other party is typing,' so I waited and waited."

Those last three words were bitten out particularly clearly, and she drew out the tone, slow and light. It sounded especially like teasing.

Through the phone, Liang Shi embarrassedly pinched her ear.

Soon, Xu Qingzhu sent another message: "Just like now."

Liang Shi: "?"

"What about now?" Only when Liang Shi spoke did she realize her voice hadn't recovered yet. It still had the hoarseness of just waking up, a bit... soft and babyish.

She wanted to retract it, but Xu Qingzhu's voice message had already come through again: "Like now—I waited and waited, but you still didn't say anything."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I did say something." Liang Shi defended herself. "Remember to eat breakfast."

Xu Qingzhu: [Oh.]

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. After sitting on the edge of the bed thinking for a few seconds, she sent a voice message, carrying a hint of eager anticipation: "Let me treat you to an escape room this Saturday. I heard a new immersive escape room just opened in the north part of the city, and it's supposed to be really good."

Two seconds later, she added: [Just forget about my embarrassing behavior last night.]

Xu Qingzhu's tone carried a smile, deliberately lilting upward: "What embarrassing behavior? If you hadn't mentioned it, I would have forgotten."

Liang Shi: [...]

How could she possibly forget?!

She clearly remembered everything very well.

Liang Shi was about to send something else when Xu Qingzhu sent: [An immersive escape room? If Teacher Liang wants to make it out of the escape room unscathed, how much alcohol would that take?]

Liang Shi sent six dots to express her speechlessness.

Xu Qingzhu: [You'd probably have to drink an entire distillery dry.]

Liang Shi: [...]

Liang Shi jabbed at her screen hard: [Just you wait! I definitely won't be scared.]

In the voice message Xu Qingzhu sent back, her tone was provocative: "Really?"

Liang Shi: "Of course it's true. Whoever gets scared is a puppy!"¹

Xu Qingzhu: "Okay~"

A single word would normally be too short to send as a voice message, but Xu Qingzhu's "okay" was quite spirited—the ending was drawn out very long and carried a hint of amusement, as if mocking her.

Liang Shi's competitive spirit was ignited.

She thought: I'll definitely be able to walk out of that escape room without drinking.

It's just an escape room, right?

She didn't necessarily have to play a horror theme. She could do a puzzle-solving one.

But the system was really such a dog². Why did it have to issue that kind of mission?

Staying inseparable for 24 hours, plus going to an escape room, and coaxing Xu Qingzhu to sleep...

Whatever, no one could refuse two hundred thousand yuan.

Footnotes:

¹ **Whoever gets scared is a puppy (誰害怕誰小狗)**: A common Chinese expression used when making bets or dares, similar to "whoever chickens out is a loser." Being called a "puppy" or "dog" in this context is a playful insult suggesting cowardice.

² **The system is really such a dog (系統是真的狗)**: Chinese internet slang where calling something/someone a "dog" expresses frustration or complaint about unfair or annoying behavior. Similar to saying "the system is really something" or "the system is so mean."

Chapter 91-3

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Liang Shi applied a very thick layer of foundation to the side of her neck, but the marks were still visible.

In the end, she simply gave up.

During the script discussion meeting in the morning, Yan Xi kept staring at her neck, making her feel somewhat uncomfortable.

After the meeting ended, Yan Xi came over and asked: "What's that on your neck?"

Liang Shi said expressionlessly: "A mosquito bite."

Yan Xi: "..."

A few seconds later, Yan Xi pressed her finger on Liang Shi's neck. Liang Shi immediately stepped back: "What are you doing?"

Yan Xi rolled her eyes: "Do you think I've never watched TV?"

Liang Shi: "...So what?"

"Is that a strawberry planted by my gorgeous beauty?" Yan Xi's heart was sour like a lemon. Her fingers twisted together, but her face maintained a calm expression. "You... how hateful!"

Liang Shi: "..."

Seeing how Yan Xi was very angry but didn't dare show it, Liang Shi found it amusing. So after a moment, she leaned over and said in a whisper like a devil: "Good that you know."

Yan Xi: "?"

"So she's not your gorgeous beauty." Liang Shi smiled gently, but there was a hint of aggressiveness in that smile. "She's my gorgeous beauty."

Yan Xi: "!"

The director saw the two of them whispering and was quite pleased: "I thought it would take you two quite a while to get familiar with each other, but you've already become close? That's great. Young people communicate well with each other. Now that you two have built rapport, filming will go smoother."

Hearing this, Liang Shi looked at the director and nodded at him: "We've gotten a bit closer."

Yan Xi secretly gritted her teeth. Liang Shi could feel her staring at the strawberry mark on her neck, eyes practically shooting flames.

The director smiled: "Liang Shi, you have more experience in acting. Help guide Yan Xi more—she's a complete newcomer."

Liang Shi nodded: "Okay."

But Yan Xi said: "I don't need it. I learn things very quickly."

The director shook his head on his own: "Acting depends on natural talent. No matter how fast you learn, it won't work without that innate spark."

"I have that innate spark too." Yan Xi proudly raised her chin. "Anyway, I'll definitely act well. I don't need her to teach me."

Liang Shi just smiled without saying anything.

The director merely laughed at her youthful temperament—she wouldn't talk like this once she stumbled and fell.

Anyone could see that the director's relationship with her was different. Mainly because Yan Xi's identity was special. Even if she hadn't invested money to join the production, she was still considered half a little ancestor¹ of the crew.

But Yan Xi was certain she wouldn't stumble. Since she was young, she had never failed at anything she wanted to learn.

Wasn't it just acting?

She could definitely do it.

At the very least, she'd be better than Zhao Ying.

Zhao Ying, who had inexplicably gained an enemy: ...

Zhao Ying didn't care.

Seeing her like this, Liang Shi didn't annoyingly step forward to act as a teacher either. During meetings, she was responsible for listening and would occasionally interject a few words to discuss with others. After meetings ended, she would take a brief rest.

Initially, there weren't any scenes for Liang Shi. If she was busy, she could leave. Two days before her scenes were scheduled, the staff would call her to come to the set.

So after the meeting, Liang Shi said goodbye to the director and Zhao Ying separately, then drove away from the set heading home.

She could just complete that mission before official filming began.

Staying inseparable for twenty-four hours... what about going to the bathroom?

The system replied: [Going to the bathroom doesn't count. The "staying inseparable" in the mission refers to eating together, washing dishes together, sleeping together, including those two key points.]

Liang Shi understood. Just like the previous travel mission—although it said three days and two nights, the most important part was those two nights.

On her way leaving the set, Liang Shi called Gu Zhaoyuan to ask if he had time now. She had something to discuss with him.

Gu Zhaoyuan told her to come directly to Ci'ai Nursing Home²—he was always there.

Liang Shi checked the distance. Although both where she was filming and Ci'ai Nursing Home were in the suburbs, they were on opposite ends spanning more than half the city. It would take over two hours to drive.

It was already almost evening, so Liang Shi suggested that he come to the city center tomorrow and they could meet then.

Gu Zhaoyuan immediately became alert: "Is it related to Xingyue?"

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Yes, she wants to meet with you. We can discuss the details tomorrow. If I have time tonight, I'll ask Gu Xingyue again."

Gu Zhaoyuan took a deep breath: "Okay, is 8 AM tomorrow okay for you?"

At the mention of anything related to Gu Xingyue, Gu Zhaoyuan immediately became anxious, wishing he could meet with Liang Shi right now.

But Liang Shi smiled helplessly: "Brother Gu, don't get worked up. Xingyue's situation might not be great right now, so we need to give her enough time. Since she took the initiative to propose meeting, it means she won't run away. Don't panic."

Her form of address immediately brought them closer.

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly: "Miss Liang, I... I never thought Xingyue would still be alive."

Liang Shi said firmly: "She's still alive, and you will see each other again. And she's a gentle yet strong girl."

Gu Zhaoyuan sighed with emotion: "Yes, she always has been."

Liang Shi then agreed on a meeting place with Gu Zhaoyuan, setting the time for 9 AM, before hanging up the phone.

Footnotes:

¹ **Little ancestor (小祖宗):** As explained in previous chapters, this is a term used for someone who is being treated like royalty or must be handled with care, usually due to their special status or background.

² **Ci'ai Nursing Home (慈愛養老院):** "Ci'ai" literally means "benevolent love" or "compassionate love." This is the nursing home where Gu Zhaoyuan works and where the elderly members of the Gu family (related to Gu Xingyue's storyline) reside.

Chapter 91-4

That evening, Liang Shi sent a text message to Gu Xingyue asking if it was convenient to call.

Gu Xingyue replied: [Not convenient. Just send a message.]

Liang Shi didn't let down her guard. She was worried that Yang Jiani might be the one holding Gu Xingyue's phone and replying. So she suggested to Gu Xingyue that they add each other on WeChat, saying she wanted to ask about Rainbow's usual performance at school.

She did it flawlessly. Then Gu Xingyue added her on WeChat and sent the first message: [Rainbow usually performs very well. It's just that today she was trapped in the sports equipment room. She might be traumatized, so please remember to comfort her tonight.]

Rainbow was trapped in the equipment room?

Trapped?

Those two words were quite telling.

Liang Shi replied: [Okay, thank you, Teacher Qi. Sorry to trouble you.]

She immediately called Zhou Li to verify with Rainbow. Rainbow said firmly: "I wasn't trapped at all. We didn't have PE class today, but a boy from the older class was playing soccer and kicked our classroom window and shattered it."

Liang Shi acknowledged this and asked her a few more everyday questions, which Rainbow answered one by one.

Before she could ask about Qi Jiao's recent situation, Rainbow took the initiative to say: "Sister Liang, does Teacher Qi have something on her mind lately?"

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked.

Rainbow said in confusion: "She was drinking alcohol in the office. There was alcohol in her water cup... And the day before yesterday during class, she suddenly cried."

Liang Shi was surprised: "The day before yesterday?"

Wasn't that the day before Gu Xingyue called her?

"Yeah, her whole eyes were red from crying." Rainbow sighed. "We all tried to comfort her, but it didn't work. It seems like she experienced something major..."

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "I understand. Thank you, Rainbow."

"Oh right." Rainbow said: "There's one more thing."

"What?" Liang Shi asked.

"Last week Teacher Qi came to class limping." Rainbow said: "She said she bumped into something, but I saw marks on her ankle, very much like marks from being tied with nylon rope."

"Nylon rope?!" Liang Shi and Zhou Li exclaimed in surprise at the same time.

Liang Shi was surprised because she felt that Yang Jiani would absolutely do such a crazy thing, but she was also surprised that Rainbow could accurately describe something like nylon rope.

Zhou Li was surprised because using nylon rope to tie someone—that was clearly a crime!

"Are you sure?" Liang Shi still hadn't completely accepted Rainbow's genius girl persona. After all, she was only a five-year-old child. Ling Dang didn't even know what nylon rope was right now, yet Rainbow could already accurately describe objects based on marks. So to be safe, she asked again.

Rainbow said: "Not entirely sure, but I feel it's either nylon rope or binding cord, because I only saw it briefly and couldn't look carefully."

Zhou Li said in a low voice from the side: "You can trust her judgment. Her... father is a mystery enthusiast."

This was the first time Liang Shi had heard Zhou Li mention Rainbow's father. Rainbow had mentioned before that her father was abroad and that she was mixed-race.

But since Zhou Li said so, Liang Shi believed it.

Rainbow's judgment had never been wrong.

After verifying with Rainbow, Liang Shi looked at her phone screen. It still showed her conversation with Gu Xingyue.

Gu Xingyue said Rainbow was trapped in the sports equipment room today, but Rainbow said someone had shattered their classroom window today.

—This should be the information Gu Xingyue was trying to convey.

She didn't dare act rashly now.

While she was carefully thinking through the connections, Xu Qingzhu had just finished washing up and came out of the bathroom. She was holding a towel drying her hair and casually asked about Gu Xingyue's situation.

Liang Shi immediately spilled everything like beans pouring from a bamboo tube. Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Don't you need to hesitate at all?" Xu Qingzhu said: "This is after all a very confidential matter."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Do I need to with you?" Liang Shi urged: "Teacher Xu, you're smarter. Help me figure this out. All I can think of is that Gu Xingyue is trapped, but if she was really locked up, she wouldn't be able to send me messages. So what's the correct information she's trying to convey to me?"

Xu Qingzhu walked to the sofa and sat down on the carpet, leaning against the sofa. The towel was casually draped over her shoulder. Her half-wet hair was sticking up and she hadn't had time to tidy it. Instead, she took out a piece of paper from the cabinet and asked Liang Shi for her phone.

Liang Shi opened the chat page and placed it in front of her. After Xu Qingzhu scrolled through, she copied down those few sentences.

Then she asked Liang Shi word by word what Rainbow had said.

As Liang Shi spoke, Xu Qingzhu recorded.

While speaking, Liang Shi picked up the towel from Xu Qingzhu's shoulder and started drying her hair.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly drew in a sharp breath. Liang Shi's movements paused: "What's wrong? Did you figure it out?"

"You pulled so hard my scalp went numb." Xu Qingzhu said: "Do you think I could have figured it out yet?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She slowed down her movements and said in a low voice: "Sorry."

Xu Qingzhu continued looking down and piecing together these bits of information. Liang Shi helped her dry her hair while also thinking.

A few seconds later, both of them suddenly spoke at the same time: "Gu Xingyue tried to resist but was discovered by Yang Jiani?!"

Xu Qingzhu turned around, and the two of them made eye contact.

Then Liang Shi indicated for Xu Qingzhu to speak while she listened quietly.

Xu Qingzhu connected all these information points together: "It was originally a destructive incident of shattering glass, but Gu Xingyue said Rainbow was trapped in the sports equipment room. So she's telling us that if she's locked up, she's very likely locked in a place with a lot of miscellaneous items. And Rainbow said her leg was injured a few days ago with marks on her ankle, indicating she was recently abused. Why would Yang Jiani abuse her? Because she did some destructive things, such as resisting, and was discovered by Yang Jiani, so Yang Jiani abused her again."

"Also, why would she suddenly cry during class? As a teacher, crying during class is a big taboo." Xu Qingzhu was a bit puzzled here. "She's already suffered Yang Jiani's long-term abuse, so she shouldn't react to this kind of thing. She wouldn't cry in class just because of being abused. So what major event affected her? And drinking alcohol in her water cup—this rebellious behavior suddenly happening to her, could it be related to Director Gu and the others?"

But Liang Shi suddenly thought of someone. She pressed her lips together: "Perhaps it's also related to other things."

She took out her phone to check her blacklist. Just as she was about to remove Cheng Can's number from the blacklist, a call from an unknown number came through.

Liang Shi answered. Xu Qingzhu stayed quiet, but her head moved in Liang Shi's hand, indicating she should continue drying her hair.

Liang Shi dried her hair with one hand and answered the phone with the other: "Hello?"

The voice on the other end was somewhat garbled, and the background was noisy. She couldn't make out what was being said. Liang Shi put it on speaker and told the other party: "I can't hear clearly."

Suddenly, an angry roar erupted from the other side: "Everyone shut the fuck up!"

Liang Shi with the speakerphone on: "..."

She and Xu Qingzhu were both startled at the same time. Xu Qingzhu's resentful gaze turned toward her. Liang Shi gently patted her head to soothe her.

Xu Qingzhu continued sitting on the carpet with her arms crossed. Both of them recognized who was on the other end.

After Cheng Can's roar, when she spoke again her voice was hoarse: "Hello?"

Liang Shi quickly said: "I'm here."

"Damn." Cheng Can clicked her tongue. "Liang Shi, you're being so well-behaved. I'm really not used to it."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Say what you need to say quickly. If there's nothing, I'm hanging up." Liang Shi said irritably.

Now Cheng Can was comfortable. She spoke extremely fast, sounding a bit embarrassed, but it was too garbled—you had to really work hard to make out what she was saying: "Have you seen Qi Jiao recently?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi was silent for a few seconds, then said coldly: "Can you speak normally?"

Cheng Can: "...I'm asking if you've seen Qi Jiao recently. Don't you know her?"

Liang Shi: "You tell me first—did you break up with Qi Jiao? Or did she catch you fooling around with another woman?"

There was two seconds of silence on Cheng Can's end, then the sound of lighting a cigarette: "Damn, really can't hide anything from you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi gritted her teeth: "So which one is it?"

Cheng Can paused: "Both. The day before yesterday she came to find me, and I was... and then she broke up with me."

Liang Shi: "..."

Cheng Can scoffed lightly: "But the problem is she already broke up with me once before. After we got back together, we haven't even met once. I have some needs, you know... Liang Shi, you should understand."

Liang Shi couldn't help but curse: "...I understand jack shit."¹

Footnotes:

¹ **I understand jack shit (我懂個屁):** A crude colloquial expression literally meaning "I understand a fart," used to emphatically deny understanding or agreement with something ridiculous. The vulgarity emphasizes Liang Shi's frustration and complete rejection of Cheng Can's excuse.